TOPIC 5: HIGHLIGHTING YOUR STRENGTHS CREATING AN ELEVATOR SPEECH

Topic OBJECTIVES: The learner will:

- Understand what an elevator speech is
- Understand when to use an elevator speech
- Understand what employers are looking for when they ask for a writing sample

Topic OUTCOMES: The learner will:

- Create an elevator speech
- Practice their elevator speech with at least three people

Topic ACTIVITIES:

Opening Activity

- Think about someone famous (so that other people will know that person as well) that you admire. Give everyone two minutes to write down the person's name, what he/she does, what her/his strengths are and why someone would want to hire him/her. Have everyone introduce themselves as that person to the group.
- Have a bunch of candy, bags of chips, drinks, etc., and have everyone choose one. Give people two minutes to create an advertisement (and write it down) for the item they chose. Have all participants present their item. Instruct them to be creative, descriptive and highlight what is great about the item.

Large Group Discussion

Objectives:
- Students will understand what an elevator speech is.
- Students will understand what should be included in an elevator speech.
- Students will understand when to use an elevator speech.

Time: 20 minutes

Materials:
- Flip chart with the following written on it: An elevator speech is a short (15-30 second, 150 word) sound bite that succinctly and memorably introduces you. It spotlights your uniqueness. It focuses on the benefits you provide. And it is delivered effortlessly... A great elevator speech makes a lasting first impression, showcases your professionalism and allows you to position yourself.
  ~ *Dale Kurow* http://www.dalekurow.com/elevator
- Additional flip chart, markers

Ask students if they have ever heard of an elevator speech. Ask them to explain what they think an elevator speech is. Share the flipchart with the elevator speech description and ask for a volunteer to read it out loud. Discuss with students what should be included in an elevator speech and capture what they say on flip chart (or have one of the students capture what they say on flipchart). Discuss when an elevator speech should be used (career fairs and formal networking opportunities, casual networking opportunities, to answer college and job interview "tell me about yourself" questions, when requesting an application, informational interviews, voicemail for potential employers, etc.).

Technical/Research Activity

Objective: Students will explore how people and/or products are marketed

Time: 20 minutes

Materials: Computers with internet access

Have students go back to their notes from the opening activity. Work in small groups (2-3 people) to improve the introductions or advertisements.

Famous person: Go online to find out more information about the person you introduced in the opening activity. What did you forget to highlight? How is the person 'marketed' online?

Item: Go online to find out more information about your product. Can you find an advertisement for the product online? How does it catch people's attention? What did you forget to highlight?

Have the individuals in the small groups work together to improve the opening introductions/advertisements and re-present the people/products to the larger group.

Writing/Reflection/Assessment

Objectives:
- Students will explore how to create an elevator speech.
- Students will practice creating their own elevator speech.

Time: 20 minutes

Materials: Handout: "Creating an Elevator Speech," pens/pencils

Ask students to complete "Creating an Elevator Speech." Encourage them to help each other — to be open to feedback and available to offer suggestions to other participants. After everyone has created their elevator speech, take about 10 minutes for people to move around the room and practice using their elevator speech. Come back together as a group and discuss how it felt to use their elevator speech. What do they remember from other people's speeches? What really stood out?

Creating an Elevator Speech

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Answer the following questions:

Who are you?

How can you grab the listener's attention?

What are your key strengths?

What positive adjectives describe you?

What will you bring to an employer? What can/do you do?

What do you want to get out of the elevator speech? Why are you telling this person about yourself? What is your request for action? (talk to them about potential opportunities, ask for a card, ask for advice, get an application, etc.)

Possible requests for action:
from http://www.quintcareers.com/job-search_elevator_speech.html

At a career fair: "I'd like to take your business card, as well as leave my networking card and resume. Would it be possible for me to get a spot on your company's interview schedule?

In a networking situation: "What advice do you have for me? Can you suggest any employers I should be contacting?"

Cold-calling an employer: "When can we set up a meeting to discuss how I can help your company?"

Telephone or e-mail situations: "May I send you my resume?" (For in-person situations, you should always have resumes handy).

Elevator Speech Examples

from http://www.expressionsofexcellence.com/sample_elevator.html

For A Lawyer for Non-Profits
"I'm saving the people who are saving the world! (She pauses and smiles). I'm Alice Anderson, a lawyer for non-profits. My company, Anderson NonProfit Strategies, based in the San Francisco Bay Area, specializes in helping non-profits keep their fund-raising legal. For more information e-mail me: alice@anpslaw."

For The Self-Employed
"Hi, I teach people how manners make money & politeness promotes profits in the market place. I teach etiquette to youth and adults. I'm Carolyn Millet, and it's my pleasure to meet you!"

For Trainers
"I turn conflict into agreement. I'm Robbie Gordon of the Conflict Resolution Institute. My workshops & coaching reduce your conflict. We teach people how to understand, discuss and resolve conflict so they can live happier lives. Let us replace the conflict in your life."

For An Insurance Agent
"I'm a money man with a plan: I make sure the money keeps flowing when your income stops. (Pause). Somewhere along the line, for one reason or another, you will no longer be working. My plans insure that individuals and their families are prepared for that day when it comes. (Another pause). Let's review your plan to make sure the money flows unabated. I'm Mark Eckhout with MML Investors Services."

"My firm takes over where Walt Disney left off. I'm Chal Daniels, and I will show you how to make your dreams come true. What is something you have always dreamt of doing? (Pauses and listens intently.) I can help you make your wish come true. Here is my card, call me, I'd love to work with you. I give you my assurance our insurance can help you dream big dreams."

BOG Participant (Create your elevator speech here):